

Gannets, cormorants, and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Suliformes
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	60

This substantial group of water birds is characterized by long, daggerlike or slightly hooked bills; long wings with extended “elbow” joints giving extra reach; and unusual feet, having all four toes joined by webbing. Gannets and boobies are strictly marine birds, while some of the cormorants

can also be found on fresh water far inland. They include successful and abundant species, some very widespread, while others have a restricted geographical range, exploiting rich feeding areas associated with localized oceanic conditions.

Anatomy

Gannets are capable swimmers and divers, and spend long periods far from land. Cormorants and shags have poor waterproofing and come to land regularly to dry their plumage. They are buoyant swimmers, but heavy, waterlogged feathers help them dive from the surface for fish, while gannets and boobies must reach greater depths by plunge-diving from a height.

Breeding

Some shags and cormorants breed in huge colonies on rocky islands, exploited for the copious guano or droppings of these fish-eaters. Others build bulky stick-nests—colonies typically kill the trees that support them. Gannets have highly ritualized displays and social behavior to ensure that breeding in their dense island colonies is synchronized and effectively organized, and so maximize breeding success.

DOUBLE-CRESTED CORMORANT
Eating almost nothing but fish, cormorants dive from the surface, wings tightly closed, propelling themselves with powerful feet. Large fish are brought to the surface and swallowed whole.



Phalacrocorax auritus

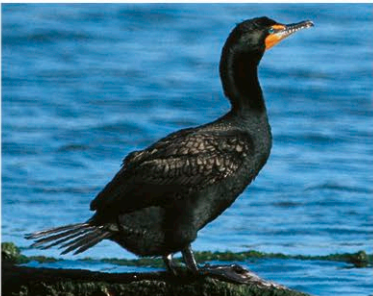
Double-crested cormorant



Length 30–36 in (76–91 cm)
Weight 3¼–4½ lb (1.5–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



This bird is the only cormorant in North America that is widespread inland as well as on the coast. As with other cormorants, it has a streamlined body, a serpentine neck, and large, webbed feet. Unlike other cormorants, for a brief period in spring, it has a double crest on the head. Its increasing population has made it a serious pest of catfish farms on the Mississippi.



Phalacrocorax carbo

Great cormorant



Length 32–39 in (80–100 cm)
Weight Up to 7¾ lb (3.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location E. North America, S. Greenland, Europe, Asia, southern Africa, Australia



One of the world's most widespread coastal seabirds, the great cormorant is also common inland and can be found on almost any large area of water—fresh, brackish, or saline, natural or artificial—in Europe, Asia, and Africa. It makes its nest in a wide range of habitats, from cliffs and bare rocks to trees and reedbeds. The great cormorant breeds in colonies, in some cases returning to the same location year after year, although pairs of birds usually remain together only for a single season.



black body with bronze sheen

stout legs

POWER SWIMMING



Although the great cormorant prefers to hunt in shallow water, it can dive to depths of 100 ft (30 m) or more. When underwater, it swims under its prey with its wings pressed closely to its body. Sturdy legs with large webs make for powerful propulsion to catch fast-moving fish.

LONG AND SLEEK
The great cormorant has a spare, streamlined body, a flexible, serpentine neck, and a stout, hooked bill to help grasp fish.